

Laura Otero, Ph.D.

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Leadership: Instructional Technology

M.S., Education: Online Teaching & Learning

B.A., Human Communication: English Subject Matter Preparation

University of the Cumberlands

California State University, East Bay

California State University, Monterey Bay

EXPERIENCE

San Jose State University — San Jose, CA

July 2025 – present

Assistant Professor & Program Coordinator MSIDT, School of Information

As an Assistant Professor, I serve as the program coordinator for the new Master of Science in Instructional Design & Technology program, a 100% online degree that prepares students for careers in teaching, training, organizational management, and human performance improvement. This role involves strategic program development, curriculum design, faculty collaboration, and research in instructional design and educational technology. Key responsibilities include:

- Design and teach graduate courses in instructional design, learning theory, and educational technology
- Developed and launched new graduate certificate programs in instructional design and digital innovation
- Collaborate with industry partners to enhance student learning opportunities
- Provide program assessment and continuous improvement initiatives
- Conduct research in instructional design and emerging educational technologies
- Recruited, supervised, and evaluated lecturer faculty and graduate student research assistants

Accomplishments include:

- Served as the department's AI Ambassador, providing guidance to other faculty on AI integration and usage
- Contributed to the design of the Ed.D. in Educational Technology new program
- Led launch of MS in Instructional Design & Technology (MSIDT), including creation and approval of 6 new graduate courses (IDT 202, 204, 211, 212, 213, 214)
- Developed graduate certificate in Instructional Design Foundations to support enrollment pathways and workforce alignment
- Convened and chaired MSIDT Program Advisory Committee (academic + industry)

Naval Postgraduate School — Monterey, CA

February 2025 – July 2025

Instructional Design and Faculty Academic Coordinator, NPS Extended Campus

As a full-time associate faculty member, I collaborated with faculty, staff, and contractors across the Naval Postgraduate School, the Navy, and the Department of Defense to design, develop, implement, and evaluate distance learning programs for the NPS Extended Campus (NEC). I also led coordination efforts and communicated faculty needs to the NEC contracting team, which is an interdisciplinary group of instructional designers, videographers, programmers, student support coordinators, project managers, and web/graphic designers to provide holistic support for the NPS distance learning programs. I managed the 12-person team by scoping out requested projects, assigning work, and ensuring timely and quality deliverables. Key accomplishments include:

- Secured over \$300,000 to close the funding gap by forging partnerships with various stakeholders in the first 45 days of service.
- Developed and operationalized a new, customized course quality framework and rubric to establish a continuous improvement process for distance learning courses.

- Designed and implemented a streamlined scenario-based learning multimedia development process by leveraging generative AI tools.
- Enabled team performance by securing cutting-edge software tools for learning object development.

My work supported the growth and sustainability of the NPS Extended Campus, contributing to the educational advancement of future leaders across the Department of Defense.

California State University Monterey Bay — Seaside, CA
Online Education Coordinator, Center for Academic Technologies

March 2022 – February 2025

As the full-time Online Education Coordinator, I led campus efforts to plan, develop, and analyze online education opportunities, both technical and programmatic for the institution. I identified stakeholder needs, evaluated institutional data, collaborated with faculty and administrators, and served on participatory governance committees to guide the design, development, and enhancement of online offerings. I also offered training and mentorship for faculty to help them effectively deliver instruction online and adapt to the pedagogical demands of the digital age. Key accomplishments include:

- Supported student services and instructional departments throughout the university, and worked with deans/directors to implement an array of services and opportunities.
- Evaluated and provided recommendations for physical resources, labs, and spaces as well as virtual and digital resources.
- Oversaw digital accessibility remediation program and a team of student personnel.
- Secured and managed diverse funding including multiple grants for various professional development through multiple funds (\$150,000+).
- Authored and led the CSU-wide AI training program for faculty and instructional designers with 2000+ completions and mentored 10 new facilitators to expand the training program.
- Initiated and led the development of the campus-wide Digital Learning policy to meet compliance standards.
- Expanded a campus-wide online course quality peer review process by certifying 20+ faculty in the Quality Matters framework.

California State University Monterey Bay — Seaside, CA
Adjunct Faculty, School of Computing & Design

August 2022 – July 2025

As an adjunct faculty member in the School of Computing & Design, I taught upper-division undergraduate courses for the Communication Design program as well as graduate-level online courses in the Instructional Science & Technology program. This work involved curriculum development, lecturing, graduate student advising, student learning outcome assessment, active student outreach, data monitoring, graduate student advising, and online/hybrid course delivery. 5+ different courses taught (see details in the Teaching Experience section below).

Hartnell College — Salinas, CA
Instructional Technologist

April 2014 – March 2022

As the instructional technologist for a multi-campus system, I directed the activity of the Professional Development Center and provided leadership and support for the college's Distance Education program. I also provided strategic leadership for the professional development programs and instructional technology initiatives on campus and instruction for the distance education certification program for faculty. My goal was to improve student access and success by empowering faculty and staff through equity-minded professional development and digital literacy programs. Key accomplishments include:

- Developed and delivered the emergency campus-wide online teacher & remote worker training programs that enabled 500+ faculty and 100+ staff to continue working during the COVID-19 college closure.
- Chaired the Classified Professional Development Subcommittee to design and launch a 2-year-long leadership academy designed to prepare staff for leadership positions and managed a \$34,000+ grant budget.

- Served as lead project manager for the successful integration of the Vision Resource Center statewide professional development portal.
- Developed curriculum and provided online/classroom instruction for 500+ faculty and staff, and issued online teaching certifications for 300+ faculty.
- Provided key data and recommendations for the \$500,000 Ready, Set, Go! grant and used funds to launch and manage the Distance Education Academy in collaboration with faculty partners.

Comcourse, Inc. — Santa Cruz, CA
Course Developer

August 2011 – April 2014

- Trained 50+ faculty and 8+ instructional designers at partner institutions in an Ed Tech start-up environment.
- Coordinated with subject matter experts across multiple disciplines to develop interactive multimedia.
- Collaborated with and set deadlines for faculty to develop content.
- Converted 50+ face-to-face courses to an online course delivery format.

TECHNOLOGY & INDUSTRY

- **Meridian Rise, Chief Academic Officer and founding partner** (2026-present): On an ad-hoc basis, I provide consultative expertise in instructional design and AI-powered educational technology solutions for a variety of clients, from government to corporate organizations.
- **Copal.ai Technical Advisor** (2023-2025): I served as a technical advisor and lead for learning and development for a start-up company that leverages AI for multiple higher education applications, including course mapping, video FERPA compliance, and OER textbook/videobook development. In this role, I provided strategic leadership and oversaw a team of developers and UI/UX specialists to develop products.
- **Faculty Professional Development Consultant, Laura Otero** (2022-2025): I served as an independent contractor providing consultative expertise on Artificial Intelligence applications and other subjects related to teaching and learning in education. I presented at the University of San Francisco, Salinas High School District, throughout the California State University system, South Sudan (through UNICEF), various libraries, and more.
- **Consultant, FlipOUT Educational Services** (2013-2014): Founded a consulting business and provided course development, instructional design, and training support services for community partners.
- **Software proficiencies:** Artificial Intelligence tools (various), Articulate Storyline, Camtasia, ScreenPal, Photoshop/Pixlr, various generative AI tools (e.g., MidJourney, Dall-E, Gemini, ChatGPT, Perplexity, Elicit, Claude), various web design/editing platforms (Squarespace, TerminalFour, OmniCMS, Drupal, Dreamweaver), Microsoft Office Suite, Google Suite.

INSTRUCTIONAL EXPERIENCE

San Jose State University – San Jose, CA

Fall 2025 – present

Assistant Professor & Program Coordinator, School of Information

- Master of Instructional Design & Technology program
 - IDT 202: Systematic Design of Instruction and Human Performance
 - IDT 204: Theories of Teaching, Learning, and Human Cognition
 - INFO 298: Special Topics
- Student evaluations above university norms (Fall 2025 & Spring 2026 SOTE mean = 5.0)

California State University Monterey Bay – Seaside, CA
 Adjunct Faculty, School of Computing and Design

Fall 2022 – Summer 2025

- Bachelor of Communication Design program
 - CST 300L: Major Proseminar, Fall 2022-Spring 2024
- Master of Instructional Science & Technology program
 - IST 524: Instructional Technology, Fall 2023
 - IST 520: Theories of Learning and Instruction, Spring 2024-Spring 2025
 - IST 595: Special Topics: Artificial Intelligence Tools for Teaching and Learning, Summer 2024-Summer 2025
 - IST 522: Instructional Design, Fall 2024
 - Serving as a Capstone (Thesis) Advisor, Fall 2023-Summer 2025 (5+ students)
- Student evaluations consistently above university norms

California State University Monterey Bay – Seaside, CA

Spring 2022 – February 2025

Instructional Designer, Center for Academic Technologies (faculty development courses)

- CAT 104: Online Instruction Certification, Winter Institute 2024
- CAT 103: Introduction to AI Tools for Teaching & Learning, Summer Institute 2023 & 2024
- CAT 101: Digital Accessibility & Equity, Summer Institute 2022
- CAT 102: Resilient Teaching, Summer Institute 2022
- Teaching Cooperative Workshops: Learning Outcome Writing & Course Mapping, AI Tools for Teaching & Learning, Course Mapping with AI Tools

Hartnell College – Salinas, CA

Spring 2014 – Spring 2022

Instructional Technologist, Professional Development Center (faculty & staff development courses)

- PDC 100: Introduction to Tech Tools, 2014-2022
- PDC 101: Introduction to Canvas, 2015-2022
- PDO 100: Foundations for Success in Online Teaching, 2020-2022
- PDO 101: Introduction to Teaching Online, 2016-2022
- PDO 102: Virtual Classroom Skills, 2017-2022
- PDW 102: Creating Webpages with Omni CMS, 2017-2022

Additionally, I have facilitated faculty development courses and webinars through the California State University Chancellor's Office for the CSU system, through UNICEF at Juba University in South Sudan to prepare faculty to teach in their social work program, and through the CCC's California Virtual Campus to support AI faculty training for the community college system.

GRANTS & BUDGET OVERSIGHT

- 2025: \$315,000 fundraised to continue NPS Extended Campus staffing & operations (secured & managed)
- 2024: \$100,000 in internal funds to drive Summer Institute Artificial Intelligence training (managed)
- 2024: \$17,000 Quality Matters Online Course Services Grant (secured & managed)
- 2023: \$17,000 Quality Matters Online Course Services Grant (secured & managed)
- 2022: \$17,000 Quality Matters Online Course Services Grant (secured & managed)
- 2022: \$15,000 Affordable Learning Solutions/OER Grant (secured)
- 2018-2019: \$34,000 Classified Staff Professional Development Grant (managed)

GRANTS, PRESENTATIONS & PUBLICATIONS

- Otero, L. (2027, pending). *The AI Third Wheel Effect: Examining human-AI collaboration in faculty-instructional designer partnerships*. [Randomized controlled trial designed; RSCA Seed Grant awarded].
- Aguiñaga, J., Ghosh, S., Mooradian, N., Shaffer, G., & Otero, L. (2027, in press). AI Literacy Readiness Among Academic Library Professionals in the Era of Generative AI. Hawaii International Conference on System Sciences (HICSS).

- Aguiñaga, J., Otero, L., & Shaffer, G. (2027, textbook chapter proposal accepted). Leadership Competencies in the Age of AI: Leading Digital Transformation in Academic Libraries.
- Wang, K. & Otero, L. (2027, in press). Emerging AI Competency Expectations for Instructional Designers: Evidence from California Job Data. *Journal of Applied Instructional Design*.
- Otero, L., Shaffer, G., & Akers-Gifford, K. (2026/7, submitted). Teaching the Teachers: Instructional Design, Academic Librarianship, and the Recognition of Educational Expertise.
- Otero, L. (2026/7, submitted). *Lowering Technical Barriers: Agentic AI and Instructional Designer Collaboration in Immersive Learning Development*.
- Otero, L. & Beem, C. (2026). *AI Demystified: Separating Fact from Fiction*. Invited public lecture, Salinas Public Library.
- Otero, L. (2025). Generative AI Training for CSU Board of Trustees. *California State University Board of Trustees Meeting*, Long Beach, CA.
- Otero, L. (2025). Experimenting with Generative AI to Enhance Teaching & Learning. *Online Teaching Conference*.
- Otero, L. (2025). Writing Measurable Learning Outcomes with Generative AI. *California Outcomes Assessment Coordinators Hub Friday SLO Talk*.
- Otero, L., Lara M., & Yamashita, J. (2025). Emerging generative artificial intelligence use by educators in the California State University system. *Proceedings INTED2025, Spain*, 2961–2965.
<https://doi.org/10.21125/inted.2025.0784>
- Otero, L. (2024). Introduction to Generative AI workshop. *The Monterey Bay Area Cooperative Library System (MOBAC)*.
- Otero, L. (2024). Course Mapping with AI: Leveraging Tools for Alignment workshop. *California Virtual Campus-Online Education Initiative (CVC-OEI)*.
- Otero, L., Hosmer-Jolley, J., Santucci, S., Moore, L., & Froshman, J. (2024). The New Game-Changers in Higher Education: How AI will Challenge, Support, and Transform Higher Learning. *22nd Ethics and Responsible Business Forum at CSUMB*.
- Otero, L. (2023). Opening Pandora's Box: Developing AI Training for Higher Ed. *38th Annual DET/CHE Conference*.
- Otero, L. (2023). Building Relationships Between Instructional Designers and Faculty Through Exemplary Leadership. *38th Annual DET/CHE Conference*.
- Española, L. & Otero, L. (2023). Digital Accessibility & Equity: Building Self-Paced Professional Development Opportunities for Faculty. *Accessing Higher Ground Conference*.
- Otero, L. & Beem, C. (2023). Generative AI Workshop. *University of San Francisco Speaker Series*.
- Otero, L. & Española, L. (2023). Digital Accessibility & Equity: Building Self-Paced Professional Development Opportunities for Faculty. *Peralta Equity Conference*.
- Otero, L. M. (2023). *Building relationships between instructional designers and faculty: Cultivating social capital through exemplary leadership* (Publication No. 31147095) [Doctoral dissertation, University of the Cumberlands]. ProQuest Dissertations and Theses Global.
- Otero, L. (2023). Critical Conversation about Cheating – Strategies and Best Practices to Encourage Academic Integrity. *CSU Monterey Bay Winter Institute panelist*.
- Otero, L. (2021). Redesign your Online Course: Resources for Success and Equity. *Hartnell College Convocation*.
- Otero, L. (2021). Canvas Studio: Enhance and Capture Lectures in your Online Courses. *Hartnell College Student Success Conference*.
- Otero, L. (2020). Regular & Effective Contact: Accreditation Compliance in Distance Education Courses. *Hartnell College Convocation*.
- Otero, L. (2019). Accessibility & Section 508 Compliance in Online Courses. *Hartnell College Student Success Conference*.

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT & SERVICE

Drivers of Educational Technology/California Higher Education – San Diego, CA

- DET/CHE Women Mentorship Program (2025)

- DET/CHE Leadership Program Cohort (2023)

CRE@TLA California State University Monterey Bay– Seaside, CA

- S.T.E.M. Academy for Inclusive and Culturally Responsive Teaching (2023)

Quality Matters – Annapolis, MD

- Certified Master Course Reviewer (2024)
- Certified Peer Course Reviewer (2023)
- Certified Instructional Designer (2022)

National Council for Mental Wellbeing – Jefferson City, MO

- Mental Health First Aid Training (2023)

Association of California Community College Administrators – Sacramento, CA

- Admin 001: So, You Want To Be An Administrator? Cohort (2022)

Hartnell College – Salinas, CA

- Classified Leadership Academy Cohort 2 (2022)
- Classified Leadership Academy Cohort 1 (2021)
- Leadership Institute (2019)

Instructional Technology Council – Mount Royal, NJ

- Distance Education Leadership Academy Cohort (2021)

Campus Pride – Charlotte, NC

- Campus Pride Safe Space Training (2021)

San Jose State University – San Jose, CA

- Co-Chair, Facilities, Technology, and Sustainability Subcommittee (2026)
- Member, Strategic Planning and Resource Committee (2026)
- Member, Curriculum Committee (2025)

Naval Postgraduate School – Monterey, CA

- Member, Accreditation and Assessment Steering Committee (A2SC) (2025)
- Member, Quality Assurance Subcommittee (A2SC) (2025)

California State University Monterey Bay – Seaside, CA

- **California State University Academic Senate (systemwide):** Commended by the CSU Academic Senate in resolution AS-3679-24/AA/FA Artificial Intelligence: Empowering CSU Faculty Colleagues
- Member, President’s Artificial Intelligence Taskforce (2024-25)
- Member, Online Education/Digital Learning Working Group (2023-25)
- Faculty Representative, Disability Advisory Committee (2023-25)
- Faculty Representative, Lecturer Resource Group (2023-25)
- Campus Lead, Online Course Services Professional Learning Community (2022-25)
- Member, Instructional Designer Common Interest Group for the CSU (2022-25)
- Member, Extended Reality Common Interest Group for the CSU (2022-25)

Hartnell College – Salinas, CA

- Professional Development Committee (2014 – 2022)
- Chair, Classified Professional Development Subcommittee (2019 – 2022)
- Distance Education Committee (2014 – 2022)
- Administrative Governance Council (2020 – 2022)
- Online Services Committee (2016 – 2022)

- **Technology Development Council** (2014 – 2022)
- **Institutional Effectiveness Council** (2014 – 2017)
- **Collective Bargaining Committees:** Employee-Employer Relations Committee (as needed, 2017 – 2022), Negotiations Team (2016 – 2022, 2 contract cycles)
- **Task Forces:** Emergency Distance Education Task Force (2020), Canvas Implementation Steering Committee (2015 – 2016), Paperless Campus Task Force (2020), Accreditation Team Subcommittee Standard IIC (2015 – 2016), Professional Development Committee Grants Task Force (2014)

California Community Colleges Chancellor's Office Committees – Sacramento, CA

- CVC-OEI Common Course Management System (CCMS) Advisory Committee (2020)